It was from this period, too, for the first time in the history of the Mughals, that the royal mirzas were kept at court well into adulthood. As we have seen, Mirza Hakim would be the last Timurid prince to control an appanage. When Akbar dismantled the appanage system, he had Mirza Hakim's young sons, Kaikobad and Afrasiyab, imprisoned in Hindustan. From now on, the only candidates eligible to aspire to the throne would be Akbar's direct descendants. The Padshah would keep his heirs close to the vortex of imperial power so that he could monitor their activities himself. Akbar had already accorded his three sons mansabs in 1577, at the ages of eight, seven, and five respectively, marking their prestige at a young age. As the three boys grew into young men there was a constant eddying of noblemen around each one, as the mirzas unfolded their ambitions according to their personality and talent.

With the powerful Kachhwahas already aligned to him through his wife, Salim pushed back against Akbar's tight control by looking further afield for supporters who would one day buttress his claims to rule. He welcomed into his household former supporters of Mirza Hakim, whom Akbar did not tolerate, men like Lala Beg Kabuli and Zamana Beg. He courted members of the recently displaced Kashmiri royal family, such as Amba Khan Kashmiri, who would prove to be valuable allies in the years to come. Salim was also beginning to watch the two men closest to his father, Abu'l Fazl and Faizi, with a certain degree of flinty and corrosive judgement. The poet Urfi had been blocked from gaining full-time employment at the Mughal court by Faizi, and the professional frisson between the two men soon turned into a deep loathing. In 1589, upon the death of Urfi's patron, Hakim Abu'l Fath Gilani, it was Salim who became his patron, along with Zain Khan Koka and Abdur Rahim. The three men, writes Munis Faruqui, had a 'shared dislike of the brothers Shaikh Abu'l Fazl and Faizi, whose arrogance and abrasiveness', as well as their jealously guarded proximity to the emperor 'had made them notorious and unpopular figures at the imperial court'.

Besides attempting to chart his own course, Salim also had to cope with the enormous pressure of being his father's eldest son. Akbar must have appeared superhuman to his sons and this pressure was, in all likelihood, a major contributing factor to Salim becoming addicted to wine and opium at exactly this stage. 'One day I mounted to go hunting,' wrote Salim in his extremely candid autobiography. 'Since I overdid it and got exhausted, a